Graphic Design

The Basics of the Pen Tool

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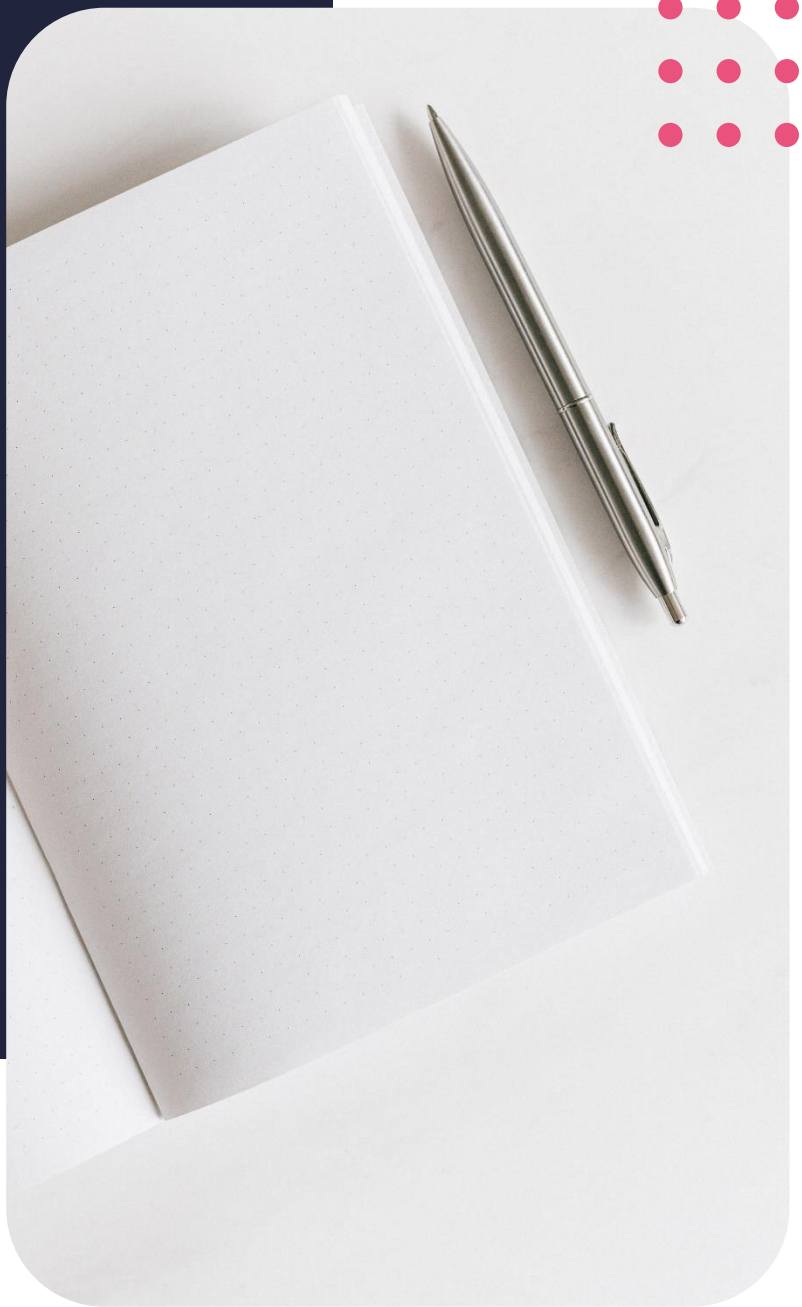


Lesson outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Lesson outcome 1: Introduction to the pen tool
- Lesson outcome 2: Why is the pen tool important?
- Lesson outcome 3: Do I need a drawing tablet?
- Lesson outcome 4: How do I use a pen tool?

Introduction

Design is an ever-changing field. A designer cannot do the same thing in the same way as he/she has always done. It is a field where you need to keep learning every day since new techniques, methods, programs and ways are developed daily. The biggest threat to your design career is thinking you have it all figured out.

This can be said to any creative career.

Jeffrey Zeldman is a designer, author and entrepreneur. This quote links very well with the fact shared in the previous slide. Jeffrey states that one should not worry about people stealing your ideas. Rather worry the day they stop stealing your ideas." It is a compliment if someone see you as a design inspiration as it shows that you do something right and people look up to you. Thinking that you know everything will let you stagnate and not grow as a designer; this is also a dangerous phase where your ideas will just remain the same and not make a difference any longer.

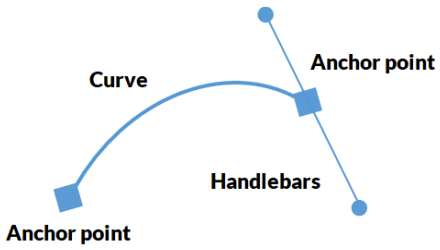
Never allow yourself to stagnate and be the person that everybody wants to "steal".

Introduction to the pen tool

I'm sure you all have been waiting for this moment, however, the process of learning the pen tool does not happen overnight. It takes lots of time and dedication, but the reward is so good!

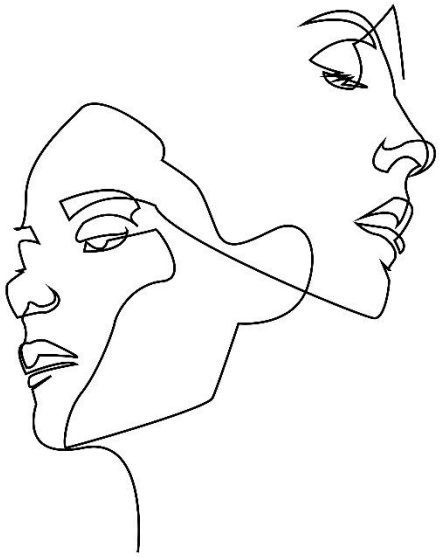
Our lesson today will entail the process of learning the pen tool amongst other tools that I will teach you. We will look at explaining what the pen tool is, why it is so important and what it is used for. This lesson is going to be practical and I would suggest you watch the demos again to make sure you understand working with the features I will be teaching you today.

The pen tool, like the name implies is a drawing tool. Instead of creating already designed shapes, you have the freedom of creating custom shapes and lines with the pen tool by defining anchor points and adjusting the curves created in between these anchor points (or nodes).



The curves can be adjusted using handlebars that extend from these anchor points. This might not make a lot of sense now, but as soon as I show you how the pen tool works, it will all come together.

I would like to show you examples of artwork created by using mostly the pen tool.



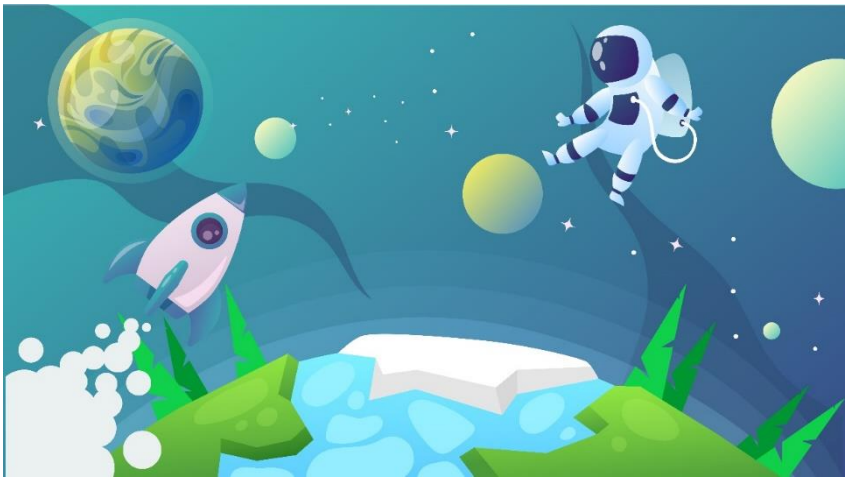
Probably the simplest form of the pen tool. Simply drawing a line to create a shape or figure. Note that having an artistic ability does really help when it comes to using the pen tool, however all is not lost. During this lesson, I will show you how to import actual created designs – hand drawn or even digitally and simply tracing it using the pen tool's features.

In this specific image, the hills, trees, clouds as well as hiker are done using mostly the pen tool.

More examples, here, by creating the outlines of the scene, you make use of the pen tool. In conjunction with other tools, the rest of the details were added. The starting point however is the pen tool.

Looking at the figures, you can clearly see the shapes as well as a darker outline defining each figure.

You can even create a water colour effect, even though it takes a lot of practice and time. Just like drawing in real life, so it is with the pen tool. If you have a natural artistic ability, you should be good with digital illustrations as well.



Basic shapes in conjunction with more organic shapes and a combination of gradients and bright colours can create a comic feel.

Why is the pen tool important?

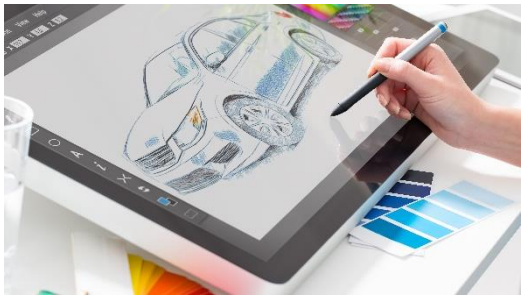
It is a well-known fact that the pen tool is the most powerful tool in specifically Illustrator. The pen tool can also be used in Photoshop and InDesign.

The pen tool is the tool you will probably make use of the most, especially in Illustrator. It is thus crucial to master the pen tool.

The pen tool is important because you have the freedom to create whatever your creative mind can think of. Avoiding the pen tool, because you find it intimidating will only limit your ability in working with all these programs.

Do I need a drawing tablet?

A drawing tablet is simply a tool that helps you to draw (like you would on paper) but digitally…



You have a digital pen; known as a stylus and a screen or flat surface you use to draw on. Drawing tablets come in a variety of shapes and sizes. The high-end drawing tablets normally come with a screen or you can simply get a more affordable one that does not have a screen – you will simply then refer to your computer screen. It is not necessary to have a stylus or drawing tablet and you will manage without one. If you are interested in illustration as a career, then I think it might be a good investment but not owning a stylus does not make you any less capable.

How do I use a pen tool?

It might seem like very basic, but the pen tool is quite something to get used to. Also, why do I create a whole lesson on explaining the pen tool? Because we use it in all three programs. It is mostly used in Illustrator and Photoshop, but you can use it in InDesign as well.

The good news is that as soon as you get the hang of the pen tool in Illustrator, it becomes natural in the other programs as well. In Illustrator we mostly use the pen tool for illustrations, from basic flat coloured drawings to more complicated illustrations. We create logos with it and even retrace rasterised logos. You can also use it in conjunction with the type on a path tool.

In Photoshop, the Pen tool is also used for digital illustrations perhaps in conjunction with the brush tool. It is also used for deep-etching, which is a selection technique I will show you a bit later in this lesson.

With InDesign, I personally don't use the pen tool that much, since I normally have my illustrations already created in either Illustrator or Photoshop. But, like we learnt in the previous lesson, you can use the pen tool here as well. It has similar functions to Illustrator but are more limited.

I am starting with a demo on polygonal art using the pen tool in Illustrator. Polygonal art or low poly was basic computer-based 3D graphics. Low poly graphics consisted of triangles mostly and today it is rather used as a stylised feature in design. It is very popular under graphic design artists.

Although not as difficult to create, polygonal art is very intense and takes up a lot of time, this is why I have also sped up the demo, otherwise you would watch me do it in real time for 4 hours or even longer. After our polygonal art demos, I will explain on how to import images taken from your phone into Illustrator.

If you're up for the challenge, simply take any photograph, why not create a nice profile picture for yourself polygonal art style?

It might take some time, but the result is worth it.

Conclusion

Our lesson today was quite practical and our lessons in future will become even more practical.

You got introduced to the amazing pen tool today and on how to make use of its basic features. You realised that with even knowing only basic features of the pen tool, you are still able to create amazing artwork.

Graphic design is all about practice and since we will be doing more practical tasks, I hope you are ready. Make sure that you practice and make sure that you enjoy what you are doing!